could drag many other ‘respectable’ figures into custody with him. Shanmugham was a mine of information on the LTTE as he gave them logistical support in Tamil Nadu.

Shanmugham was taken to his house for the recovery of two letters written by Dhanu and Shubha. One was to Pottu Amman and the other to the LTTE’s women’s intelligence-wing head, Akila. Akila was another name that Athirai was known by. In their letters, both the human bombs reassured them that they would remain loyal to their mission.

The next person to give the SIT information was Mariappan, Shanmugham’s neighbour in Kodiakkarai. He had seen Murugan and other LTTE cadres staying in Shanmugham’s luxurious house. He had been given Murugan’s box to bury in the forest for safekeeping, but for some reason, Shanmugham had taken it back from him the very same day. He had admitted that that had been done at the behest of a Tamil Nadu politician. The SIT continued Mariappan’s interrogation to figure out the nexus between Shanmugham and the powers that be who had extended support to the LTTE through his services. Else, the SIT believed, Shanmugham would have been arrested much earlier.[5]

A large team consisting of the Tamil Nadu police, the CRPF, Verma and Ragothaman launched a combing operation in the Kodiakkarai forests from that evening until the next morning and recovered six VHF Japan-made wireless sets, arms, ammunitions, 121 cartons of high explosives, sixty-six drums of fuel, and Indian currency of over Rs 20 lakh buried in deep pits. Even in pitch dark, Shanmugham guided the SIT to the exact locations of the pits without a problem. To win his trust further, the sleuths granted him permission to meet his family and have food from home. But they took him back to the government circuit house in Vedaranyam in an attempt to maintain pressure on him. He had much more to disclose. The LTTE had hidden gold biscuits in the forest too, and Murugan’s bag was hidden somewhere around.[6]

Incidentally, Shanmugham’s maternal uncle, Seetharaman, also a smuggler and known for his closeness to the LTTE, was also in police custody. The SIT brought him face to face with Shanmugham. In no time